Participation within the BRICS club, as seen from Brasília, is thus primarily a means of amplifying Brazil's international status and voice, in accordance with an explicit Brazilian strategic doctrine known locally as "soft-balancing," which involves making coalitions with other middle powers in order to enhance Brazil's voice in multilateral fora dominated by the United States and other great powers.[241] The concept dates from the 1980s and remains a core tenet of the obligatory graduate curriculum for Brazilian diplomats. The European Union has been viewed as a positive model for what Brazilian leadership within the global South might achieve. President da Silva articulated these ideas with his characteristic flair. When asked by the *Financial Times* in 2009 whether the BRICs was a "meaningful group," da Silva responded, "Yes, it is. The major example I can give you is the EU. It seemed impossible 30 years ago . . . It's like when you meet a new girlfriend. If you only look at her defects and flaws, you'll get nowhere. But if you look on the bright side, you might end up getting married."[242]

Such views give context to Brazil's willingness to back Russia in resisting Western financial sanctions in response to Russian meddling in Ukraine, which might seem puzzling given Brazil's outspoken promotion of democracy, national sovereignty, and nonintervention. Brazilians explain their choices by reference to their nation's consistent preference for quiet persuasion and nonconfrontation: that is, even if Brazilian policymakers strongly disapproved of President Putin's choices, they object even more strongly to public criticism, which they judge as certain to be unproductive.[243] Moreover, Brazil shares with its fellow BRICS a "common aversion" to being shut out of global deal-making. Cooperation within the BRICS to resist Western financial sanctions derives from this tradition. It is also true that Brazilian trade relations with Russia have deepened as a result of attenuated trade links between Russia and Western Europe, as new markets have opened up for Brazilian agricultural produce, for example; but this is a consequence, not a cause.

In sum, the BRICS primarily have been conceptualized in Brazilian government, academic, and media circles within the South-South framing, not as a new departure in foreign policy. The most valued role of the BRICS and BRICS collective financial statecraft has been to give a positive bump to Brazil's international status and voice. For example, Brazilian officials were particularly proud of having joined with India and China to subscribe